

The Revolt of "Mother"

Mary E. Wilkins Freeman · 1890

First published: Harper's Bazar, Sep 1890

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

AP edition (standards shown for this framework only)

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson 1: introduction (author, context, reception, overview)
4. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
5. Unit test (eleven rigor versions) with answer keys and scoring guides
6. Final paper
7. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/A_New_England_Nun_and_Other_Stories/The_Revolt_of_"Mother" (revision 14965993), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 8–11 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 2 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Revolt of "Mother" suggest about women's rights in marriage?
- What does The Revolt of "Mother" suggest about home and dignity?
- What does The Revolt of "Mother" suggest about quiet rebellion?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards: AP

AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN

AP English Literature and Composition big ideas (our summaries; apcentral.collegeboard.org)

Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five

Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	*Introduction: author, context and reception* The Revolt of "Mother"	2 × 90 min (180 min)	*women's rights in marriage* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Introduction: author, context and reception • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Introduction to The Revolt of "Mother"

Author biography

Mary E. Wilkins Freeman was born in Randolph, Massachusetts, on 31 October 1852 and grew up in Randolph and Brattleboro, Vermont. After her parents' deaths left her with little money, she supported herself by writing; her collections A Humble Romance (1887) and A New England Nun (1891) portray the lives, especially women's lives, of small New England villages. In 1926 she received the William Dean Howells Medal for fiction. She died on 13 March 1930.

Historical and cultural context

Set in rural New England in the late nineteenth century, when farm wives had no legal claim to family property and few public voices. The title echoes the Revolution of 1776.

Publication and reception, then and now

First published in Harper's New Monthly Magazine in September 1890; collected in A New England Nun and Other Stories (1891).

Then: Very popular; Freeman later wrote that it was unrealistic.

Now: Taught for its feminist themes and local colour.

Overview (spoiler-free)

Sarah Penn learns that her husband Adoniram is building a new barn on the spot where, forty years before, he had promised to build her a new house.

Main themes

- women's rights.
- marriage and communication.
- quiet rebellion.

Why it matters

It shows quiet, persistent resistance and invites comparisons to modern equality debates.

Spoilers · teacher only

While Adoniram is away, Sarah moves the family into the barn; he returns, is astonished, and agrees to fit it up as a house.

Lesson plan (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)

Before we open The Revolt of "Mother": How do you stand up for yourself without shouting?
Prompt: Before we open The Revolt of "Mother": How do you stand up for yourself without shouting?

8–18 min · Key terms · I do (10 min)

local colour; dialect; characterization; allusion.

18–28 min · Mini-lecture: author, context, reception · I do (10 min)

About the author. Mary E. Wilkins Freeman was born in Randolph, Massachusetts, on 31 October 1852 and grew up in Randolph and Brattleboro, Vermont. After her parents' deaths left her with little money, she supported herself by writing; her collections A Humble Romance (1887) and A New England Nun (1891) portray the lives, especially women's lives, of small New England villages. In 1926 she received the William Dean Howells Medal for fiction. She died on 13 March 1930. The world of the book. Set in rural New England in the late nineteenth century, when farm wives had no legal claim to family property and few public voices. The title echoes the Revolution of 1776. Publication and reception. First published in Harper's New Monthly Magazine in September 1890; collected in A New England Nun and Other Stories (1891). Then: Very popular; Freeman later wrote that it was unrealistic. Now: Taught for its feminist themes and local colour.

28–40 min · I do: the book in one passage · I do (12 min)

“I hadn't no idee you was so set on't as all this comes to” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 166). Adoniram's surrender.

> *I hadn't no idee you was so set on't as all this comes to (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 166)*

Think-aloud: “I hadn't no idee you was so set on't as all this comes to” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 166). Adoniram's surrender.

40–55 min · We do: overview and themes · We do (15 min)

What the book is about (no spoilers): Sarah Penn learns that her husband Adoniram is building a new barn on the spot where, forty years before, he had promised to build her a new house. Themes to track: women's rights.: marriage and communication.: quiet rebellion.:

55–70 min · You do: reading journal · You do (15 min)

Set up a reading journal: one page per theme with a prediction and a question.
Task: Set up a reading journal for The Revolt of "Mother": one page per theme, each with a prediction and a question.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)

Why does The Revolt of "Mother" still matter? It shows quiet, persistent resistance and invites comparisons to modern equality debates.
Anchor question: Why might The Revolt of "Mother" still be taught today?
Facilitation: It shows quiet, persistent resistance and invites comparisons to modern equality debates.

80–87 min · Exit ticket · You do (7 min)

Why does Sarah move into the barn? Answer: To force Adoniram to keep his promise; words had failed.
Exit ticket: Why does Sarah move into the barn?
Answer: To force Adoniram to keep his promise; words had failed.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)

Tomorrow we begin reading: The Revolt of "Mother".

Teacher notes · sources: Britannica, "Mary E. Wilkins Freeman" (https://www.britannica.com/biography/Mary-E-Wilkins-Freeman); Mary E. Wilkins Freeman, A New England Nun and Other Stories (1891) (https://www.gutenberg.org/)

Flags (verify before teaching):

- Sources differ on the first venue: our story metadata says Harper's Bazar, while many anthologies cite Harper's New Monthly Magazine (September 1890). Verify before printing.
- Freeman later criticized the story as unrealistic; this is usually traced to her 1917 Saturday Evening Post essay "Who's Who—and Why." Verify before quoting.

Lesson 2: The Revolt of "Mother"

Focus: a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home

Objective: Students will analyze how characterization develops in “The Revolt of "Mother"” by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: CCSS RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4 · IN 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.11

Content note (): No significant sensitive content flagged; preview as usual.
Student preview: Nothing in this story needs a special warning.
Suggested language: “Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?”

Teacher only · spoilers

For forty years Sarah Penn has waited for the new house her husband Adoniram promised. Instead he builds another barn. While he is away buying a horse, she moves the family and furniture into the new barn and makes it a home. Adoniram returns, is stunned, and weeps, saying he will put up partitions and windows: he never knew she was so set on it.

Background: Published in Harper's Bazar in 1890. Freeman wrote about rural New England, where farm wives had little legal say over property.

Significance: A regionalist story about a woman's independence; often paired with A Jury of Her Peers and The Story of an Hour.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
How can someone stand up for themselves without shouting? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to quiet rebellion because.... Content note before we start: Nothing in this story needs a special warning.
Prompt: How can someone stand up for themselves without shouting?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to quiet rebellion because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: she acts rather than argues.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: sedulous — careful and persistent; scuttled — ran with short quick steps; inspecting — looking at closely; examining; mumbled — talk indistinctly; usually in a low voice; cambric — a fine, thin cotton or linen cloth. "scuttled": From Middle English scuttel, scutel, from Old English scutel "dish, platter", from Latin scutella, diminutive form of Latin scutra "flat tray, dish", perhaps related to Latin scutum "shield"; compare Dutch schotel and German Schüssel. "inspecting": From Latin inspectum, past participle of inspicere "to look into", from in "in" + specere "to look at", equivalent to in + spect. "cambric": From Cambrai, a French commune where it was manufactured.
Words: sedulous: careful and persistent · scuttled: ran with short quick steps · inspecting: looking at closely; examining · mumbled: talk indistinctly; usually in a low voice · cambric: a fine, thin cotton or linen cloth

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Published in Harper's Bazar in 1890. Freeman wrote about rural New England, where farm wives had little legal say over property. A regionalist story about a woman's independence; often paired with A Jury of Her Peers and The Story of an Hour. Characterization: Sarah is patient and firm; Adoniram is silent. Dialect: New England speech. Allusion: Sarah's move compared to historical "revolts." Watch for the barn: Adoniram's priorities; it becomes a home.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "What are they digging for, mother" (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 23). The question. That is characterization at work: Sarah is patient and firm; Adoniram is silent.

> *What are they digging for, mother* *(The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 23)*

Think-aloud: I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "What are they digging for, mother" (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 23). The question. That is characterization at work: Sarah is patient and firm; Adoniram is silent.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: The end. Look at the craft: New England speech. Ask: How does this line connect to quiet rebellion? Expected: She acts rather than argues. (The end.)

> *Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph* *(The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 165)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: The end. Look at the craft: New England speech.
Ask: How does this line connect to quiet rebellion?
Expected answer: She acts rather than argues. (The end.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the story for characterization, dialect (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Revolt of "Mother" develops the idea of a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and conflict shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words failed. When the text says “Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 165), it shows this directly. Adoniram admits "I hadn't no idee you was so set on't," and "Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph."
Task: Annotate the story for characterization, dialect (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Revolt of "Mother" develops the idea of a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and conflict shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words failed. When the text says “Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 165), it shows this directly. Adoniram admits "I hadn't no idee you was so set on't," and "Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: How can someone stand up for themselves without shouting? Ask: is Sarah's revolt justified?
Anchor question: How can someone stand up for themselves without shouting?
Facilitation: Ask: is Sarah's revolt justified?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Story quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words failed. (“Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph”, The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 165). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words failed. (“Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph”, The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 165). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

> **87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)**
> Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
> *Today we saw how characterization shapes a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home. Key takeaway: she acts rather than argues.*

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Characterization:** Sarah is patient and firm; Adoniram is silent.
- **Dialect:** New England speech.
- **Allusion:** Sarah's move compared to historical "revolts."

Themes and how they develop

- **quiet rebellion:** she acts rather than argues.

Symbols and motifs

- **the barn:** Adoniram's priorities; it becomes a home.

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “What are they digging for, mother” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 23) The question.
- “Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 165) The end.
- “I hadn't no idee you was so set on't” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 166) Adoniram.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words failed.
Evidence: “Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 165)
Reasoning: Adoniram admits "I hadn't no idee you was so set on't," and "Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
sedulous (adjective)	careful and persistent	*However deep a resentment she might be forced to hold against her husband, she would never fail in sedulous attention to his wants.*	

scuttled (verb)	ran with short quick steps	*Men assembled in the store and talked it over, women with shawls over their heads scuttled into each other's houses before their work was done.*	"scuttled": From Middle English scuttel, scutel, from Old English scutel "dish, platter", from Latin scutella, diminutive form of Latin scutra "flat tray, dish", perhaps related to Latin scutum "shield"; compare Dutch schotel and German Schüssel. (Wiktionary, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/scuttle#Etymology)
inspecting (verb)	looking at closely; examining	*Penn did not speak of it, and Adoniram did not mention it to her, although sometimes, upon a return from inspecting it, he bore himself with injured dignity.*	"inspecting": From Latin inspectum, past participle of inspicere "to look into", from in "in" + specere "to look at", equivalent to in + spect. (Wiktionary, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/inspect#Etymology)
mumbled (verb)	talk indistinctly; usually in a low voice	*And the old man bent his head and mumbled.*	
cambric (noun)	a fine, thin cotton or linen cloth	*Nanny was to be married in the fall, and she was sewing on some white cambric and embroidery.*	"cambric": From Cambrai, a French commune where it was manufactured. (Wiktionary, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/cambric#Etymology)
bedrooms (noun)	a room used primarily for sleeping	*Those great box-stalls, with quilts hung before them, would make better bedrooms than the one she had occupied for forty years, and there was a tight carriage-room.*	"bedrooms": From bed + room. (Wiktionary, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/bedroom#Etymology)
profess (verb)	to declare openly	*Sarah Penn went back and stood before her husband. "Now, father," said she, "I want to know if you think you're doin' right an' accordin' to what you profess.*	"profess": From Old French professer, and its source, the participle stem of Latin profitērī, from pro- + fatērī "to confess, acknowledge". (Wiktionary, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/profess#Etymology)
arranging (verb)	put into a proper or systematic order	*He combed slowly and painstakingly, arranging his brown hair in a smooth hillock over his forehead.*	
premises (noun)	assumptions an argument is based on	*The hired man had milked, but he still hung around the premises.*	
retreated (verb)	pull back or move away or backward	*He added some more perplexed apologetic remarks; then he retreated.*	

Discussion questions

1. How can someone stand up for themselves without shouting?
2. Where does characterization appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with women's rights in marriage?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What has Adoniram promised Sarah? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · AP: unit standards] Look for: A new house
2. What is Adoniram building? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP: unit standards] Look for: A new barn
3. When does Sarah act? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · AP: unit standards] Look for: While Adoniram is away buying a horse
4. What does Sarah do? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP: unit standards] Look for: Moves the family into the new barn
5. How does Adoniram react? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · AP: unit standards] Look for: He weeps and agrees to finish it as a house
6. Retell the three most important events of “The Revolt of "Mother"” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP: unit standards] Look for: For forty years Sarah Penn has waited for the new house her husband Adoniram promised. Instead he builds another barn. While he is away buying a horse, she moves the family and furniture into the new barn and makes it a home. Adoniram returns, is stunned, and weeps, saying he will put up partitions and windows: he never knew she was so set on it.
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in “The Revolt of "Mother"”? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · AP: unit standards] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does “The Revolt of "Mother"” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP: unit standards] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: “However deep a resentment she might be forced to hold against her husband, she would never fail in sedulous attention to his wants.” What does “sedulous” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP: unit standards] Look for: sedulous: careful and persistent.
10. Reread: “Men assembled in the store and talked it over, women with shawls over their heads scuttled into each other's houses before their work was done.” What does “scuttled” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP: unit standards] Look for: scuttled: ran with short quick steps.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does “The Revolt of "Mother"” suggest about a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A regionalist story about a woman's independence; often paired with A Jury of Her Peers and The Story of an Hour.
2. Find one example of characterization in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.CHR] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
3. How does the conflict in this story shape what we understand about a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.STR] Look for: Look for the forces, people or desires pulling against each other.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words failed. Useful evidence: “What are they digging for, mother” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 23): The question. Theme link: she acts rather than argues. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. In the passage that begins “Sarah Penn's face as she rolled her pies had that expression of meek vigor which might have characterized one of the New Testament saints.”, why might Freeman have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.FIG] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “The Revolt of "Mother"”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.STR] Look for: For forty years Sarah Penn has waited for the new house her husband Adoniram promised. Instead he builds another barn. While he is away buying a horse, she moves the family and furniture into the new barn and makes it a home. Adoniram returns, is stunned, and weeps, saying he will put up partitions…
6. As the opening story, what does “The Revolt of "Mother"” set up that the rest of The Revolt of "Mother" will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.STR] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words failed. Useful evidence: “Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 165): The end. Theme link: she acts rather than argues. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.CHR] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words failed. Useful evidence: “I hadn't no idee you was so set on't” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 166): Adoniram. On characterization: Sarah is patient and firm; Adoniram is silent. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “How can someone stand up for themselves without shouting?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does diction / vocabulary appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with women's rights in marriage? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.FIG] Look for: Look for precise or unusual word

choices and their connotations.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words failed. Useful evidence: “What are they digging for, mother” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 23): The question. Theme link: she acts rather than argues. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. Background: Published in Harper's Bazar in 1890. Freeman wrote about rural New England, where farm wives had little legal say over property. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.SET] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words failed. Useful evidence: “Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 165): The end. Theme link: she acts rather than argues. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “A regionalist story about a woman's independence; often paired with A Jury of Her Peers and The Story of an Hour.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words failed. Useful evidence: “I hadn't no idee you was so set on't” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 166): Adoniram. Theme link: she acts rather than argues. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words failed. Useful evidence: “What are they digging for, mother” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 23): The question. On characterization: Sarah is patient and firm; Adoniram is silent. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Rewrite one moment of “The Revolt of "Mother"” from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN, AP-LIT.NAR] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words failed. Useful evidence: “Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 165): The end. Theme link: she acts rather than argues. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. Write three questions of your own about “The Revolt of "Mother"”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words failed. Useful evidence: “I hadn't no idee you was so set on't” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 166): Adoniram. Theme link: she acts rather than argues. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Connect this story to home and dignity: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Freeman need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words failed. Useful evidence: “What are they digging for, mother” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 23): The question. Theme link: she acts rather than argues. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Is the characterization in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words failed. Useful evidence: “Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 165): The end. On characterization: Sarah is patient and firm; Adoniram is silent. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Compare how “The Revolt of "Mother"” treats a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Revolt of "Mother" see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words failed. Useful evidence: “I hadn't no idee you was so set on't” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 166): Adoniram. Theme link: she acts rather than argues. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. As the final story, does this ending resolve women's rights in marriage? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN, AP-LIT.STR] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words failed. Useful evidence: “What are they digging for, mother” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 23): The question. Theme link: she acts rather than argues. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words failed. Useful evidence: “Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 165): The end. Theme link: she acts rather than argues. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. What question would you most like to ask Mary E. Wilkins Freeman about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words failed. Useful evidence: “I hadn't no idee you was so set on't” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 166):

Adoniram. Theme link: she acts rather than argues. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Characterization:** look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Conflict**: the forces, people or desires pulling against each other
- Also notice **Diction / vocabulary**: precise or unusual word choices and their connotations

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1] When does Sarah act?

   A. After he dies

   B. While Adoniram is away buying a horse

   C. On Sunday

   D. At night

   Key: B (While Adoniram is away buying a horse)

2. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What has Adoniram promised Sarah?

   A. A new dress

   B. A horse

   C. A new house

   D. A trip to Boston

   Key: C (A new house)

3. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does Sarah do?

   A. Leaves her husband

   B. Moves the family into the new barn

   C. Sells the farm

   D. Burns the barn

   Key: B (Moves the family into the new barn)

4. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Sarah Penn went back and stood before her husband. "Now, father," said she, "I want to know if you think you're doin' right an' accordin' to what you _____.” Word bank: profess, inspecting, sedulous, scuttled

   Key: profess

5. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “He combed slowly and painstakingly, _____ his brown hair in a smooth hillock over his forehead.” Word bank: arranging, inspecting, sedulous, scuttled

   Key: arranging

6. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Those great box-stalls, with quilts hung before them, would make better _____ than the one she had occupied for forty years, and there was a tight carriage-room.” Word bank: inspecting, bedrooms, scuttled, sedulous

   Key: bedrooms

7. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 165: “Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was _____ by her own triumph”
   Key: overcome
8. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Nanny was to be married in the fall, and she was sewing on some white _____ and embroidery.” Word bank: scuttled, sedulous, cambric, inspecting
   Key: cambric
9. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How does Adoniram react?
   A. He is furious
   B. He moves out
   C. He sells the barn
   D. He weeps and agrees to finish it as a house

   Key: D (He weeps and agrees to finish it as a house)
10. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 23: “What are they _____ for, mother”
    Key: digging
11. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “What are they digging for, mother” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 23) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: The question.
12. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 165) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: The end.
13. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “The Revolt of "Mother"”?
    A. A boy's romantic quest ending in disillusion
    B. The cost of wanting to seem richer than you are
    C. Love measured by sacrifice
    D. A wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home

    Key: D (A wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home)
14. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Revolt of "Mother"”? Sarah is patient and firm; Adoniram is silent.
    A. Characterization
    B. Imagery
    C. Metaphor
    D. Simile

    Key: A (Characterization)
15. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Revolt of "Mother"”? New England speech.
    A. Foreshadowing
    B. Theme
    C. Simile
    D. Dialect

Key: D (Dialect)

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “What are they digging for, mother” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 23) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: The question.
17. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What is Adoniram building?
    A. A church
    B. A store
    C. A school
    D. A new barn

    Key: D (A new barn)
18. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words failed. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 165).
    Sample answer: Adoniram admits "I hadn't no idee you was so set on't," and "Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph."
19. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “I hadn't no idee you was so set on't” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 166). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
    Sample answer: Adoniram.
20. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how quiet rebellion develops from an earlier story to “The Revolt of "Mother"”. Use one quotation from each.
    Sample answer: she acts rather than argues.
21. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the story: “Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words failed.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.
    Sample answer: Adoniram admits "I hadn't no idee you was so set on't," and "Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph."
22. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “And the old man bent his head and mumbled.”, what does “mumbled” most nearly mean?
    A. talk indistinctly; usually in a low voice
    B. ran with short quick steps
    C. careful and persistent
    D. looking at closely; examining

    Key: A (talk indistinctly; usually in a low voice)
23. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 165) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: The end.
24. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “However deep a resentment she might be forced to hold against her husband, she would never fail in sedulous attention to his wants.”, what does “sedulous” most nearly mean?
    A. ran with short quick steps
    B. careful and persistent

C. looking at closely; examining

D. talk indistinctly; usually in a low voice

Key: B (careful and persistent)

25. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Men assembled in the store and talked it over, women with shawls over their heads scuttled into each other's houses before their work was done.”, what does “scuttled” most nearly mean?

A. careful and persistent

B. looking at closely; examining

C. ran with short quick steps

D. talk indistinctly; usually in a low voice

Key: C (ran with short quick steps)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Middle School	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	5, 8, 10, 2, 7, 3, 17, 1, 6, 13, 11, 12, 15, 18, 14, 16	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	17, 6, 8, 4, 9, 5, 10, 1, 12, 11, 13, 15, 14, 19, 20, 16	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	9, 4, 2, 7, 17, 8, 3, 12, 11, 13, 18, 15, 19, 14, 21, 16	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	4, 1, 3, 7, 8, 10, 13, 12, 11, 14, 18, 15, 19, 21, 20, 16	recall 6, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	8, 5, 2, 3, 22, 11, 13, 12, 18, 15, 14, 19, 23, 21, 16, 20	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Freshman	10, 24, 17, 3, 6, 13, 12, 11, 19, 18, 15, 14, 16, 20, 21, 23	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	25, 17, 8, 22, 4, 11, 13, 12, 19, 14, 15, 18, 23, 21, 16, 20	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Junior	8, 10, 1, 2, 9, 13, 11, 12, 15, 18, 19, 14, 20, 16, 21, 23	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Senior	8, 4, 3, 17, 22, 11, 12, 13, 19, 18, 14, 15, 20, 23, 21, 16	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	6, 4, 17, 24, 2, 13, 12, 11, 14, 15, 19, 18, 16, 20, 21, 23	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; AP: see unit standards): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “The Revolt of "Mother",” how does Freeman show a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the characterization you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; AP: see unit standards): In The Revolt of "Mother", how does Freeman develop the idea of a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the characterization in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; AP: see unit standards): Analyze how The Revolt of "Mother" develops the idea of a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and conflict shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; AP: see unit standards): Analyze how the structure of The Revolt of "Mother" (where it begins, turns and ends) and its characterization shape the reader's understanding of a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; AP: see unit standards): Two readers disagree about what The Revolt of "Mother" suggests about a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's characterization and conflict), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; AP: AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.LAN): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Mary E. Wilkins Freeman uses characterization in The Revolt of "Mother" to complicate the reader's understanding of a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; AP: see unit standards): Situate The Revolt of "Mother" within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; AP: see unit standards): Read The Revolt of "Mother" alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home follows or bends those conventions, using the characterization as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; AP: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Revolt of "Mother" and its treatment of a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's characterization and conflict, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; AP: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads The Revolt of "Mother" as evidence for a larger claim about a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home in The Revolt of "Mother". Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; AP: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads The Revolt of "Mother" as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of a wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Revolt of "Mother".

SAT-style questions

1. *Penn did not speak of it, and Adoniram did not mention it to her, although sometimes, upon a return from inspecting it, he bore himself with injured dignity.*

As used in the text, what does the word “inspecting” most nearly mean?

A. pull back or move away or backward

B. looking at closely; examining

C. assumptions an argument is based on

D. put into a proper or systematic order

2. *Sarah Penn's face as she rolled her pies had that expression of meek vigor which might have characterized one of the New Testament saints. She was making mince-pies. Her husband, Adoniram Penn, liked them better than any other kind. She baked twice a week. Adoniram often liked a piece of pie between meals. She hurried this morning. It had been later than usual when she began, and she wanted to have a pie baked for dinner. However deep a resentment she might be forced to hold against her husband, she would never fail in sedulous attention to his wants.*

Which choice best states a central concern of “The Revolt of "Mother"”?

A. A wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home

B. A woman's brief taste of freedom

C. A girl's first encounter with death across the class line

D. Hope created by an act of sacrifice

SAT key: 1. B (looking at closely; examining); 2. A (A wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home)

Unit test

The Revolt of "Mother": end test · 90 minutes · 18 questions per rigor version (multiple choice, fill in the blank, short answer). The class rigor level picks the version; student auto-adjust applies.

Short-answer scoring guides

Middle School and HS Freshman (2 points): correct answer in a complete sentence with a detail from the text. HS Sophomore to HS Senior (3 points): claim, one accurate quotation, one sentence of explanation. AP to College Sophomore (4 points): precise claim, two embedded quotations, commentary on word choice or structure, link to theme. College Junior to Graduate (5 points): nuanced thesis, close reading of two passages, synthesis across sections, a competing reading answered. Each item lists a sample answer; partial credit is described in the app.

Unit test: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does Sarah do?
   A. Leaves her husband
   B. Moves the family into the new barn
   C. Sells the farm
   D. Burns the barn

   Key: B (Moves the family into the new barn)
2. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “He combed slowly and painstakingly, _____ his brown hair in a smooth hillock over his forehead.” Word bank: arranging, inspecting, sedulous, scuttled
   Key: arranging
3. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Nanny was to be married in the fall, and she was sewing on some white _____ and embroidery.” Word bank: scuttled, sedulous, cambric, inspecting
   Key: cambric
4. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 23: “What are they _____ for, mother”
   Key: digging
5. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Sarah Penn went back and stood before her husband. "Now, father," said she, "I want to know if you think you're doin' right an' accordin' to what you _____.” Word bank: profess, inspecting, sedulous, scuttled
   Key: profess
6. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Those great box-stalls, with quilts hung before them, would make better _____ than the one she had occupied for forty years, and there was a tight carriage-room.” Word bank: inspecting, bedrooms, scuttled, sedulous
   Key: bedrooms
7. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What has Adoniram promised Sarah?
   A. A new dress
   B. A horse
   C. A new house

D. A trip to Boston

Key: C (A new house)

8. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 165: “Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was _____ by her own triumph”

   Key: overcome

9. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What is Adoniram building?

   A. A church

   B. A store

   C. A school

   D. A new barn

   Key: D (A new barn)

10. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How does Adoniram react?

    A. He is furious

    B. He moves out

    C. He sells the barn

    D. He weeps and agrees to finish it as a house

    Key: D (He weeps and agrees to finish it as a house)

11. [mc · recall · DOK 1] When does Sarah act?

    A. After he dies

    B. While Adoniram is away buying a horse

    C. On Sunday

    D. At night

    Key: B (While Adoniram is away buying a horse)

12. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “The Revolt of "Mother"”?

    A. A boy's romantic quest ending in disillusion

    B. The cost of wanting to seem richer than you are

    C. Love measured by sacrifice

    D. A wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home

    Key: D (A wife's quiet rebellion for a decent home)

13. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 165) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The end.

14. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “What are they digging for, mother” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 23) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The question.

15. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Revolt of "Mother"”? Sarah is patient and firm; Adoniram is silent.

    A. Characterization

    B. Imagery

C. Metaphor

D. Simile

Key: A (Characterization)

16. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “I hadn't no idee you was so set on't” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 166). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
    Sample answer: Adoniram.

17. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words failed. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 165).
    Sample answer: Adoniram admits "I hadn't no idee you was so set on't," and "Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph."

18. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the story: “Sarah's action succeeds where forty years of words failed.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.
    Sample answer: Adoniram admits "I hadn't no idee you was so set on't," and "Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph."

19. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Revolt of "Mother"”? New England speech.

    A. Foreshadowing

    B. Theme

    C. Simile

    D. Dialect

    Key: D (Dialect)

20. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “What are they digging for, mother” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 23) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: The question.

21. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Sarah put her apron up to her face; she was overcome by her own triumph” (The Revolt of "Mother", paragraph 165) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: The end.

22. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how quiet rebellion develops from an earlier story to “The Revolt of "Mother"”. Use one quotation from each.
    Sample answer: she acts rather than argues.

23. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “However deep a resentment she might be forced to hold against her husband, she would never fail in sedulous attention to his wants.”, what does “sedulous” most nearly mean?

    A. ran with short quick steps

    B. careful and persistent

    C. looking at closely; examining

    D. talk indistinctly; usually in a low voice

    Key: B (careful and persistent)

24. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “And the old man bent his head and mumbled.”, what does “mumbled” most nearly mean?

    A. talk indistinctly; usually in a low voice

    B. ran with short quick steps

    C. careful and persistent

    D. looking at closely; examining

    Key: A (talk indistinctly; usually in a low voice)

25. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Men assembled in the store and talked it over, women with shawls over their heads scuttled into each other's houses before their work was done.”, what does “scuttled” most nearly mean?

    A. careful and persistent

    B. looking at closely; examining

    C. ran with short quick steps

    D. talk indistinctly; usually in a low voice

    Key: C (ran with short quick steps)

26. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Penn did not speak of it, and Adoniram did not mention it to her, although sometimes, upon a return from inspecting it, he bore himself with injured dignity.”, what does “inspecting” most nearly mean?

    A. ran with short quick steps

    B. careful and persistent

    C. looking at closely; examining

    D. talk indistinctly; usually in a low voice

    Key: C (looking at closely; examining)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Middle School	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18	recall 11, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	4, 2, 10, 7, 6, 3, 9, 1, 5, 11, 8, 13, 12, 14, 16, 19, 15, 18	recall 11, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	2, 7, 9, 6, 4, 1, 10, 11, 3, 8, 14, 12, 13, 17, 19, 15, 20, 21	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	11, 6, 8, 2, 7, 5, 1, 4, 10, 13, 12, 14, 19, 16, 17, 15, 20, 22	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	6, 3, 11, 4, 9, 1, 8, 2, 14, 13, 12, 15, 16, 17, 19, 18, 22, 21	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	1, 5, 10, 8, 9, 3, 4, 14, 13, 12, 16, 15, 17, 19, 18, 22, 21, 20	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Freshman	6, 23, 10, 24, 9, 3, 11, 12, 14, 13, 16, 19, 17, 15, 18, 22, 20, 21	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

College Sophomore	6, 25, 26, 1, 24, 4, 8, 14, 12, 13, 19, 17, 15, 16, 22, 21, 20, 18	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Junior	4, 26, 24, 23, 8, 1, 3, 12, 13, 14, 17, 15, 19, 16, 22, 20, 21, 18	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Senior	23, 9, 2, 4, 3, 10, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 19, 17, 21, 22, 20, 18	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	4, 10, 5, 26, 8, 1, 25, 12, 13, 14, 16, 17, 19, 15, 21, 20, 22, 18	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

Final paper

The Revolt of "Mother": final paper (formal literary analysis). Choose one prompt.

1. Analyze how Mary E. Wilkins Freeman develops women's rights in marriage across The Revolt of "Mother". Trace the idea through at least three moments (beginning, middle and end) and argue what the ending finally suggests.
2. Choose one recurring symbol, image or motif in The Revolt of "Mother" and argue how its meaning changes over the story and why that change matters to home and dignity.
3. Analyze a central character's choices in The Revolt of "Mother". Argue whether the story judges that character, and how its structure or point of view shapes your answer.
4. Two readers disagree about whether The Revolt of "Mother" finally endorses or criticizes its society's view of quiet rebellion. Weigh both readings and argue for one, answering the strongest objection.

Length: Middle School 500-700 words; HS Freshman 700-900 words; HS Sophomore 900-1,100 words; HS Junior 1,000-1,300 words; HS Senior 1,200-1,500 words; AP 1,300-1,600 words; College Freshman 1,500-2,000 words; College Sophomore 2,000-2,500 words; College Junior 2,500-3,000 words; College Senior 3,000-4,000 words; Graduate / PhD 4,000-6,000 words

Evidence requirement: at least 4 quotations from at least two parts of the story. Quote the reading text exactly and cite the paragraph (MLA style). HS Senior and above: one scholarly or historical source; College Sophomore and above: two, cited in MLA.

Criterion	Points	Descriptor
Thesis	20	A specific, arguable claim that answers the prompt and organizes the paper.
Evidence	25	Well-chosen, accurately quoted and cited passages from across the work, meeting the evidence requirement.
Analysis	30	Explains how language, structure and literary elements create meaning; goes beyond summary.
Organization	15	Logical progression, clear topic sentences and transitions; introduction and conclusion frame the argument.
Style and conventions	10	Formal academic voice, present tense for literature, correct grammar and MLA format.

Essay assignments

Essay: Women's rights in marriage

Middle School (600 words; AP: see unit standards): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Revolt of "Mother" teaches about women's rights in marriage. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Mary E. Wilkins Freeman develops women's rights in marriage in The Revolt of "Mother". Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Mary E. Wilkins Freeman develops women's rights in marriage across The Revolt of "Mother". Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Revolt of "Mother" (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of women's rights in marriage. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of women's rights in marriage in The Revolt of "Mother". Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Mary E. Wilkins Freeman's choices in The Revolt of "Mother" (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of women's rights in marriage, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Revolt of "Mother"'s treatment of women's rights in marriage in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on women's rights in marriage in The Revolt of "Mother" that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on women's rights in marriage in The Revolt of "Mother". Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about women's rights in marriage in The Revolt of "Mother", engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on women's rights in marriage in The Revolt of "Mother", engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Home and dignity

Middle School (600 words; AP: see unit standards): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Revolt of "Mother" teaches about home and dignity. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Mary E. Wilkins Freeman develops home and dignity in The Revolt of "Mother". Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Mary E. Wilkins Freeman develops home and dignity across The Revolt of "Mother". Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Revolt of "Mother" (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of home and dignity. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of home and dignity in The Revolt of "Mother". Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Mary E. Wilkins Freeman's choices in The Revolt of "Mother" (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of home and dignity, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Revolt of "Mother"'s treatment of home and dignity in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on home and dignity in The Revolt of "Mother" that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on home and dignity in The Revolt of "Mother". Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about home and dignity in The Revolt of "Mother", engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on home and dignity in The Revolt of "Mother", engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Quiet rebellion

Middle School (600 words; AP: see unit standards): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Revolt of "Mother" teaches about quiet rebellion. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Mary E. Wilkins Freeman develops quiet rebellion in The Revolt of "Mother". Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Mary E. Wilkins Freeman develops quiet rebellion across The Revolt of "Mother". Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Revolt of "Mother" (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of quiet rebellion. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of quiet rebellion in The Revolt of "Mother". Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Mary E. Wilkins Freeman's choices in The Revolt of "Mother" (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of quiet rebellion, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Revolt of "Mother"'s treatment of quiet rebellion in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on quiet rebellion in The Revolt of "Mother" that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on quiet rebellion in The Revolt of "Mother". Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about quiet rebellion in The Revolt of "Mother", engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on quiet rebellion in The Revolt of "Mother", engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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